

# LEG SYMPTOMS

- Screen for joint problem:
  - Check joints and ask patient to place hands behind head, then behind back. Bury nails in palm and open hand. Press palms together with elbows lifted. Walk. Sit and stand up with arms folded.
  - If joint warm/tender/swollen or unable to do all actions comfortably, **joint problem** likely →62.
- If the problem is only in the foot →66.

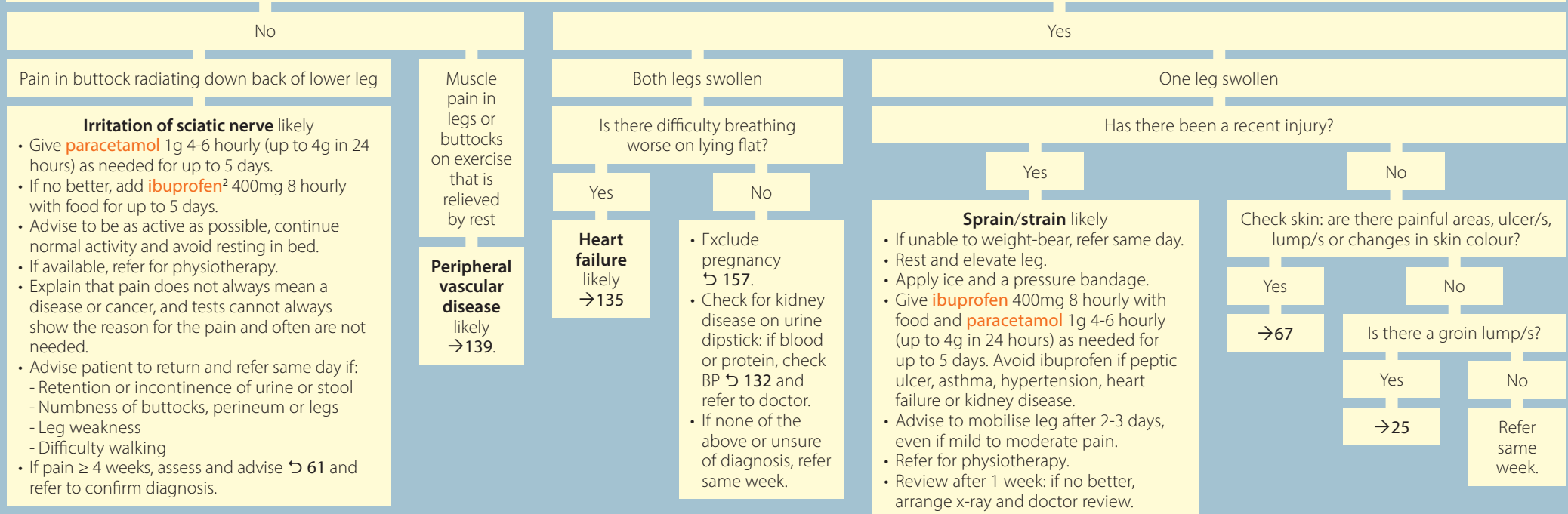
## Give urgent attention to the patient with leg symptoms and any of

- Unable to bear weight following injury, **fracture** likely ↗ 18.
- Swelling and pain in one calf: **deep venous thrombosis** likely, especially if BMI<sup>1</sup> > 30, smoker, immobile, pregnant, on oestrogen, leg trauma, recent hospitalisation, TB or cancer
- Sudden severe leg pain at rest with any of the following in the leg: numbness, weakness, pallor, no pulse: **acute limb ischaemia** likely
- Muscle pain in legs or buttocks on exercise associated with pain at rest, gangrene or ulceration: **critical limb ischaemia** likely

Refer urgently.

## Approach to the patient with leg symptoms not needing urgent attention:

- Review patient's medication. If on simvastatin and muscle pain/cramps and weakness, reduce **simvastatin** dose to 20mg at night. If no better, reduce dose further to 10mg or discuss with doctor/specialist.
- Is there leg swelling?



<sup>1</sup>BMI = weight (kg) ÷ height (m) ÷ height (m). <sup>2</sup>Avoid if peptic ulcer, asthma, hypertension, heart failure, kidney disease.